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CHAPTER I

# Ethnic Nationalism: The Construction of National Identities and Cultures

WHILE many people hoped that the early 1990s would be celebrated as the time when long-cherished dreams of European integration and unification were finally realized, it seems more likely now that these years will be remembered as a period of dramatic, and often violent, disintegration and fragmentation. The collapse of the Soviet Union and the break up of Yugoslavia, in addition to the separatist movements of western Europe and the ethnic politics of the United States, Canada, and Australia, testify to the fact that ethnic nationalism continues to be a major political force in the Western world in the final decade of the twentieth century. What Anthony Smith (1981) has called "the ethnic revival"—the surge of support for ethnic minorities demanding cultural freedoms, human rights, political autonomy, and even national independence—shows every sign of increasing in both intensity and scope.

Various reasons are cited to explain this resurgence of ethnic nationalism. Although the power of nationalist ideologies themselves has tended to seduce us with the myth that European states are ethnically homogeneous, closer examination clearly reveals the existence of many politically mobilized ethnic groups that pose a range of threats to the stability of the states in which they live. The contradiction between the widespread theoretical acceptance of the right to national self-determination and the equally widespread practical refusal of states to tolerate their own dismemberment has been a major cause of this resurgence. Other contributing factors include the recent wave of democratization that has spread through eastern Europe; alienation from increasingly impersonal, bureaucratic, and centralized states; and the declining importance of class-based political parties and movements. Uneven economic development has often frustrated the desires of regionally based ethnic groups for educational and occupational mobility and an improved standard of living. Finally, improvements in mass communication have enabled states to impose dominant national cultures and symbols more effectively on the private lives of members of minority groups. Ethnic nationalism can therefore be seen as an attempt to main-

tain or to recreate a sense of identity and community in the face of the threat of cultural assimilation or annihilation.[1]

Although in many ways the recent wave of ethnic nationalism is a continuation of a process that began in the late eighteenth century, Eric Hobsbawm has pointed out one important difference. Nineteenth-century national movements, which were often directed against huge multinational empires, were engaged in the building of nations; their goal was seen to be national unification and expansion. Furthermore, they were governed by what Hobsbawm (1990:31) has called a "threshold principle"—the principle that the right to national self-determination applied only to nations that were of sufficient size to form viable political and economic units. More recent national movements, however, which are often directed against the very states that came into being as a result of earlier national movements, are frequently accused of destroying nations; their goal is seen to be separatist and divisive. The threshold principle has been abandoned; there seems to be no limit to how small new nations can be.

Macedonia provides a tragically apt example of what Clifford Geertz (1973d:276) has described as the "self-reinforcing whirlpools of primordial discontent" that swirl around newly emerging states. After the violent breakup of Yugoslavia, the Republic of Macedonia declared its independence on September 8, 1991. Almost immediately, however, the survival of Macedonia as a sovereign and independent state was seriously threatened both on the domestic and the international fronts by a variety of nationalist ideologies and movements. In January 1992, the Albanian minority in Macedonia, which makes up over one-fifth of the republic's population, held a referendum and voted overwhelmingly in favor of "the political and territorial autonomy of the Albanians in Macedonia" and the formation of their own state, the Republic of Ilirida.

Even more ominous, however, has been the response of Macedonia's Balkan neighbors. Bulgaria, while it recognizes the existence of a Macedonian state, refuses to recognize the existence of a Macedonian nation on the grounds that Macedonians are really Bulgarians. Serbia, where some nationalists refer to Macedonia as "South Serbia," has refused to recognize the Republic of Macedonia. Finally, Greece refuses to recognize either a Macedonian state or a Macedonian nation on the grounds that everything Macedonian—the name, the people, the history, and the territory—is exclusively Greek. From a Greek perspective international recognition of the Republic of Macedonia constitutes a

[1] For further discussion of these general issues, see Connor (1973, 1977); Esman (1977); Guideri, Pellizzi, and Tambiah (1988); Smith (1981, 1983, 1986); Stack (1981); and Tambiah (1989).



threat to the cultural heritage of the Greek nation as well as the territorial integrity of the Greek state.

In this book I am concerned with precisely this aspect of the Macedonian conflict—the dispute between Greeks and Macedonians over which group has the right to identify itself as Macedonian.

## ETHNIC NATIONALISM

A great deal of ambiguity and confusion surrounds the use of terms like "ethnic group," "nation," "state," and "nationalism." Because they are employed with a variety of related but different meanings in scholarly articles, nationalist rhetoric, and everyday language, it seems appropriate to introduce this discussion of ethnic nationalism with some general definitions and brief explanatory comments.

Before the pioneering work of Fredrik Barth ethnic groups were generally understood to be social groups that shared a common origin, history, language, and culture. Barth's contribution to the study of ethnicity was to reject this reifying and essentializing approach, which suggests an equivalence between a race, a culture, a society, and an ethnic group, and offer an alternative approach in which ethnic groups are defined as "categories of ascription and identification" that people use to classify both themselves and others (1969:10). Barth's aproach allows us to understand how ethnic boundaries are defined and maintained even in situations where there are no "objective" cultural criteria distinguishing between groups, as well as in situations where individuals are able to change their identity by crossing ethnic boundaries and passing from one group to another.[2]

Nations, like ethnic groups, have traditionally been defined in terms of what they share. Hugh Seton-Watson, for example, defines a nation as "a community of people, whose members are bound together by a sense of solidarity, a commmon culture, a national consciousness" (1977:1). Images of common origin, descent, and history also serve to unite people who define themselves as members of the same nation. Ernest Gellner (1983:7) offers two definitions of a nation. The first—"two men are of the same nation if and only if they share the same culture"—suffers from the same reifying tendencies as traditional definitions of ethnicity. The second—"two men are of the same nation if and only if they *recognize* each other as belonging to the same nation"—is sensitive to the issues of self-ascription and ascription by others emphasized by Barth. Anderson's well-known definition of a nation as

[2] Other important anthropological works on ethnicity include De Vos and Romanucci-Ross (1975), Nash (1989), and Royce (1982).

"an imagined political community" (1983:15) also stresses the fact that nations are socially and culturally constructed through complex historical and political processes.

In spite of the similarities that exist between the concept of the ethnic group and that of the nation, several important differences between the two should be noted as well. These differences generally involve size, degree of politicization, and relationship to a specific territory. Nations are large, politicized ethnic groups associated with specific territories over which they seek some degree of autonomy. Nations, as opposed to ethnic groups, in other words, are people who exercise, or hope one day to exercise, sovereignty over a given territory.

The distinction between a "nation" and a "state" is extremely important. This is particularly true given the misleading way the word "nation" is used in such common expressions as "the United *Nations*" and "inter*national* affairs." Strictly speaking, in both these phrases the word "state," rather than "nation," would be more appropriate. While a nation is, or perhaps more accurately, claims to be a culturally homogeneous social group, a state is "a legal and political organization with the power to require obedience and loyalty from its citizens" (Seton-Watson 1977:1); it is "the major political subdivision of the globe" (Connor 1978:379). While states (like the former Soviet Union or the former Yugoslavia) may contain more than one nation, nations (like the Kurds or the Palestinians) may live in several states, none of which are their own.

Nationalism is the political principle according to which "the political and the national unit should be congruent" (Gellner 1983:1). Nations, in other words, should have the right of self-determination, the right to exist as sovereign and independent states. Nationalist ideologies, as Handler (1988:154) points out, are based on assumptions concerning "the existence of a geographically, historically, and culturally unique nation," which "is believed to be 'born of' and indissolubly linked to a bounded territory and a particular history." The goal of nationalist movements is to "turn the ethnic group into that more abstract and politicised category, the 'nation,' and then to establish the latter as the sole criterion of statehood" (Smith 1981:xii). Their goal, in other words, is to create a territorially bounded political unit, a state, out of a homogeneous cultural community, a nation. A state that emerges from a successful nationalist movement is known as a nation-state—a state, that is, whose political boundaries are the same as those of the nation, a state whose population is homogeneous, whose inhabitants are all members of the same nation.

It is important to remember, as Smith (1981) and Connor (1978) point out, that this ideal-typical nation-state is nowhere nearly as common as



successful nationalist ideologies have led us to believe. Many countries that are usually considered to be nation-states, such as France or Spain, in actuality contain one or more ethnic or national minorities. It is a testament to the power of nationalist ideologies that such countries can continue to see themselves, and be seen by others, as ethnically homogeneous nation-states, in spite of the internal nationalist movements that occasionally challenge their legitimacy and at times even threaten their stability.[3]

The power of nationalist ideologies also poses one of the greatest challenges to the anthropological analysis of nationalism. From a nationalist perspective nations are regarded as natural phenomena of great antiquity, whereas from an anthropological perspective nations are human constructions, cultural products of relatively recent historical processes. In Gellner's words, "Nations as a natural, God-given way of classifying men, as an inherent though long-delayed political destiny, are a myth; nationalism, which sometimes takes pre-existing cultures and turns them into nations, sometimes invents them, and often obliterates pre-existing cultures: *that* is a reality" (1983:48).

The anthropology of nationalism must avoid being taken in or coopted by the persuasiveness of nationalist myths. The anthropologist's task is to dereify the nation, to deconstruct and expose nationalist myths of the nation waiting, Sleeping Beauty–like, to be awakened from its slumber.[4] This can be done by analyzing the process of nation formation, the process by which nations, as well as national ideologies, cultures, and identities, are constructed from preexisting cultural forms. These preexisting cultural forms include conceptions of shared blood, race, language, place of origin, and religion. They are what Geertz (1973d:259) has called "primordial attachments . . . the 'givens'—or more precisely, as culture is inevitably involved in such matters, the assumed 'givens'—of social existence." As Geertz's qualification duly notes, and as the anthropology of nationalism must constantly stress, the idea that the preexisting cultural forms from which nations are built are in fact "primordial" or "naturally given" is itself one of nationalism's most powerful and most insidious constructions.

[3] Connor (1978:382) estimates that only 12 of the 132 states in the world "can justifiably be described as nation-states." However, because of the importance of self-perception and self-ascription in discussions of ethnic and national identity, I find it useful to continue to use the term "nation-state" for countries that *define themselves* as such, in contrast to multicultural or multinational states, such as Australia or the former Yugoslavia, that do not define themselves in this way.

[4] The image of the nation "awakening from sleep" is a common one in nationalist ideologies (Anderson 1991:195). In scholarly discourse, however, this image should be avoided. Because national identity is a matter of self-ascription, it either "exists or it does not; it cannot be asleep and then be awakened" (Greenfeld 1992:13).

When exposing these widespread and popularly accepted nationalist myths anthropologists must be careful not to go to the opposite extreme and imply that nations are created anew from absolutely nothing. To say that "nationalism invents nations where they do not exist," as Gellner does (1964:169), fails to take into account the many regional, ethnic, religious, and class identities that existed well before the age of nationalism.[5] If nations were totally new phenomena, if national traditions were completely discontinuous with the past, then they would not exert such power over people's lives. Any successful analysis of nationalism must, therefore, balance an emphasis on the obvious modernity of nationalism as a political principle with the equally obvious preexistence of the identities, traditions, and cultures from which it draws. Nationalism's strength lies in its ability to draw on these preexisting cultural forms, to reshape them, and to fashion from them new identities, new communities, which are nonetheless perceived to be continuous with the past. As Steven Kemper (1991:7) suggests, "nationalism needs to be seen as a conversation the present holds with the past," a conversation that "includes several voices in the present arguing about exactly what kind of past actually existed."

How then are nation-states produced? What is the relationship between nation formation and state formation? And how precisely is a national community imagined?

In its early stages a national movement must construct "an imagined community" (Anderson 1983) from a diversity of ethnic groups, social classes, and regional cultures in what is often a self-conscious and deliberate political process. It must also construct a viable state that will be able to play a part on the stage of world affairs. These two processes exist in a dialectical relationship to one another. While it is important to point out that contrary to many nationalist ideologies it is not nations that make states, it is equally important not to reverse the argument and simply claim the opposite—that states make nations. Hobsbawm, for example, falls into this trap when he states that "nations do not make states and nationalisms but the other way round," and again when he cites with approval the slogan "It is the state which makes the nation and not the nation the state" (1990:10, 44–45). In fact, both are at least partially true. The state clearly participates in the process of building the nation, but the nation, as a reality and an ideal, plays an equally important part in the process of creating the state.[6]

[5] On the existence of "nations" before nationalism, see Armstrong (1982).

[6] The relative importance of the roles of the state and the nation in the development of the nation-state will obviously vary a great deal from case to case.



The successful end result of this dialectical process is the emergence of a new nation-state in which the bonds of race, ethnicity, language, and religion, which together define the nation, are raised to the level of political principles that define the state. These bonds are domesticated, reconciled with the new civil order, and placed at the service of the new state. The result is the integration of the personally meaningful and emotionally powerful nation with the impersonal, distant, but politically powerful state. If, however, the tensions between these "primordial sentiments" and civil politics are not satisfactorily resolved in what Clifford Geertz calls the "integrative revolution," if the leaders of newly formed nation-states are not able to "construct a civil politics of primordial compromise" (1973d:308), then these new states will quickly be destroyed by the very forces that brought them into being.

Once an ethnic group has been politicized and comes to define itself as a nation, it may embark on a quest for self-determination by seeking some degree of autonomy or even outright sovereignty over a national homeland. When this goal is achieved and the nation has aquired political status as an independent state, then the entire range of organizations, institutions, and bureaucratic techniques at the disposal of the state becomes available for the further consolidation and homogenization of the nation. The creation of a state, which is the ultimate goal of a nationalist movement, contributes, therefore, in a dialectical manner to the creation of the nation, which is seen from within the nationalist movement as having created the state.

The state is created by means of an appeal to the right of national self-determination. State power is then used to complete the process of constructing the nation. The goal of such a process, which is often based on a racist or xenophobic nationalist ideology, is the assimilation and homogenization of the population of the new state so that all its citizens are also by definition members of the nation that the state embodies. Since the state is equated with the nation, being a citizen of the state is equated with being a member of the nation.

There are a variety of tools available to a newly formed state with which to create, or at least consolidate, the desired nation. Anderson (1983) points out the decisive role played by print-capitalism and the development of standardized national languages, both of which create national communities of people who read the same print language. Improved systems of transportation, modern forms of mass communication, and the implementation of large-scale programs of public works are other means by which states engage in the process of nation building. In addition state bureaucracies, particuarly in the form of educa-

tional systems and the military, play an important part in politicizing unmobilized groups such as the rural peasantry or the urban working class. This process is facilitated by the rise of commercial or industrial bourgeoisies, who often constitute the elite of nationalist movements and articulate most forcefully their political demands.

War may also contribute significantly to the process of nation formation. As Anthony Smith (1981:74–78) suggests, while it is often argued that wars are fought between nations or as a result of nationalist sentiments, it is equally true that wars themselves create nations by transforming a vague sense of ethnic difference into sharply opposed and crystallized national identities. Wars accomplish this most dubious of tasks by focusing attention on the precise territorial boundaries of the nation-states involved and by creating homogeneous, bounded national communities in opposition to "enemies of the nation," who are the epitome of otherness. Again it is important to emphasize that nation building is not entirely an official process emanating from above in the form of ideological engineering and state propaganda. It is a dialectical phenomenon involving as well an unofficial process emanating from below in the form of popular enthusiasm and national sentiment. The fact that a state plays a part in the construction of a nation does not mean that all nationalists can be dismissed as agents of the state.

The ideologies that inspire and guide nationalist movements can be understood, following Geertz (1973b:207), as systems of symbols through which these movements are able to accomplish the task of collective self-redefinition and create new national cultures from preexisting regional and ethnic ones. The symbols, images, and metaphors that constituted these preexisting cultures are politicized, generalized, and reduced to the lowest common denominator, in order to create a homogeneous or generic national culture designed to encompass all the specific regional or ethnic cultures that preceded it. Old symbols are given new meanings, and new symbols are introduced. Widely diverse oral and local traditions are replaced by a more standardized literate and national tradition. Paradoxically, then, although nationalist ideologies claim to defend and preserve traditional folk cultures, in fact they actually integrate and consolidate them into a new national culture (Gellner 1983:124).

Intellectuals and scholars from disciplines such as history, archaeology, linguistics, literature, and folklore create "the symbolic capital" (Bourdieu 1977) from which a national culture is formed. This national culture is then disseminated to the citizens of a new state through the educational system. In this way a national canon is created in a variety



of disciplines. A national history is written, the material culture of national ancestors is excavated, a national language is created, a canon of national literature is defined, and a body of national folklore is collected. This symbolic capital constitutes a national culture, which serves to legitimate a nation's existence as well as its claims to a specific identity, history, and territory.[7]

In *The Invention of Tradition*, a book frequently cited by anthropologists interested in the construction of national cultures, Hobsbawm and Ranger demonstrate that many "traditions" that nationalists claim to be very old are often in fact quite recent in origin and may even be "invented" (1983:1). In fact, the relative youth of the nation-state as a historical phenomenon virtually assures the novelty of national traditions. Once again we are confronted with the paradox that national cultures that claim to be old, and which draw the considerable power they hold from precisely this claim, are really quite new.

Hobsbawm and Ranger's argument, however, is flawed in one important respect. They make a distinction between "invented" traditions and "genuine" traditions, claiming for example that "where the old ways are alive, traditions need be neither renewed nor invented" (1983:8). This position rests on what is ultimately a false dichotomy between genuine and spurious traditions. As Handler and Linnekin (1984) have persuasively argued, all traditions, not just those that result from self-conscious political projects, must be understood as entirely symbolic constructions. The authenticity of a tradition "is always defined in the present"; it is "an assigned meaning rather than an objective quality." From this perspective tradition is "a process of interpretation, . . . a process that involves continual re-creation" (Handler and Linnekin 1984:286–87).

Many students of nationalism have remarked that the process of nation formation requires a collective remembering, the construction of a shared past, a shared history, that will unite people in a national community. As Ernest Gellner (1987:6, citing Ernest Renan) has pointed out, however, equally important are historical error, shared amnesia, and a collective forgetting. One simple, straightforward, and unambiguous national history must be written from the many complex and contradictory regional or ethnic histories that had previously been told. As citizens learn their national language, their national history, and their national folklore, they must forget their local dialects, their

[7] On the role of nationalist ideologies in the production of national cultures generally see R. G. Fox (1990). For studies of specific ethnographic cases see Borneman (1992), Handler (1988), Herzfeld (1982), Kapferer (1988), Kemper (1991), Layne (1994), McDonald (1989) and Verdery (1991).

village histories, and their regional folklores. As they remember the battles they fought together against their nation's enemies, they must forget the battles they fought against one another. And finally, as they try to remember what binds them together now, they must forget what separated them in the past.[8]

The process of nation formation, like many other social and cultural processes, is oppositional in character. A nation is defined through a process of exclusion; a self is defined in opposition to an other. The first and easiest task of nationalist movements is to stimulate "popular alienation from a foreign-dominated political order" (Geertz 1973c: 240), to convince people, in other words, of what they are not. Then, and only then, can national movements begin the far more difficult task of defining a collective subject, convincing people, that is, of what they are. Nationalist movements, therefore, are twofold in nature. First they define and reject a national other, then they define and create a national self.

With the rise of nationalism and the formation of nation-states, different cultures that had coexisted under multinational empires assume new significance. They become challenges to the homogeneous national culture of the new nation-state. In order to legitimate itself, the state needs to create a nation whose interests it will represent. In doing so the state necessarily excludes some people, since even if there did exist such a thing as a homogeneous national culture, it is very unlikely that all the people within the territorial boundaries of the state would share it. Thus any diversity of cultures, traditions, or identities that exists when a nation-state is formed, becomes, with the creation of a national culture, a threat to national unity. As the state creates the nation and welds by force if necessary a heterogeneous population into a unified body politic, some people, whose culture does not conform to the new national culture, will inevitably be left at the margins of the nation-state. At one level these people will be rejected and excluded, while at another they will be simultaneously assimilated and incorporated. It is precisely these people who eventually constitute the national minorities that are so threatening to the legitimacy of many nation-states.[9]

It is clear then that the very process of creating nations simultaneously creates national minorities. Movements of national separatism

[8] On Renan's comments concerning the importance of forgetting in the process of nation building see also Anderson (1983:15, 143; 1991:199–206).

[9] As Karakasidou (1992:131) points out, a limited degree of cultural diversity may survive the construction of a national culture. This is only possible, however, if these different cultures are defined as regional variants of one national culture and not as ethnic or national alternatives to it.



arise aimed at, or directed against, new states that claim a national homogeneity they have not yet created. What is more, they do so in the name of ethnic nationalism, precisely the same ideology in whose name the states they challenge were created. Peripheral ethnic groups, which have come to be defined as national minorities in the politicized climate that characterizes the formation of nation-states, reject the legitimacy of the state on the grounds that it is dominated by an alien group. Nationalism, by equating loyalty to the state with membership in the nation, transforms by definition members of national minorities into enemies of the state. These national minorities are potential nations themselves, and the separatist movements they engage in often lead to the creation of other nation-states, newer and even smaller still. Nationalisms spawn counternationalisms; nation-states contain within themselves the seeds of their own destruction. This is the dilemma nationalist movements confront. In order to protect their unique cultures and histories, they must create nation-states modeled precisely on those they struggled against. In doing so, however, they "lay the basis for the inner erosion" of the very cultures they seek to protect (Smith 1981:192).

As Maryon McDonald observes in *"We are not French!" Language, Culture and Identity in Brittany* (1989), the forces of modernization and urbanization that are thought to destroy minority languages and cultures are the very forces that actually create them, since it is the attempt to assimilate members of minority groups into national cultures that leads to their construction as national minorities in the first place. "The French government, in seeking to oppose minorities in the name of national unity, nurtures the very nightmare it wishes to dispel" (313). Ironically, then, a national minority, is "born disappearing" (104). Before it is threatened by the homogenizing forces of the nation-state, it does not exist anymore than the nation it defines itself in opposition to. What existed was not a national minority standing in opposition to a nation, but a complex tapestry of interwoven ethnic and regional cultures.

The existence of national minorities disproves the myth of national homogeneity by demonstrating the existence of "other" cultures within the nation-state. It shows that the complexities of multicultural and multilingual social life cannot easily be made to conform to the artificial dichotomies created by the borders of nation-states. Members of national minorities are exiles in their native land (Pellizzi 1988:154). The symbols that constitute their identity and give meaning to their lives are frequently appropriated by the nation-state in a way that excludes them. If members of national minorities seek to be accepted as full participants in the life of the nation-state, they must remember only the

nation's history and forget their own. Their history is not part of the nation's history; it must be suppressed. Their culture is not part of the national culture; its existence must be denied.

If, however, members of national minorities choose to resist assimilation and retain, or more properly, construct, their own histories, cultures, and identities, they must do so without the vast array of facilities that are available to the state, such as national universities, state primary schools, standardized print languages, and ceremonies of national independence. The only means national minorities have to resist the cultural hegemony of nation-states are the oral and unofficial tools of resistance (jokes, folkore, and protests) described so well by James Scott in *Domination and the Arts of Resistance* (1990). As nationalist movements become better established, better organized, and better financed, they begin to acquire some of the capabilities initially available only to states. In this way the struggle of national minorities against nation-states becomes a more even contest.

The ultimate outcome of such struggles depends on a variety of factors: the quality of the leadership and the financial resources of the nationalist movement as well as the policies pursued by the state itself. These policies can range from genocide and ethnic cleansing at one extreme, through assimilation and acculturation, to the granting of some degree of political or cultural autonomy at the other. The international political situation may also have an important influence on the outcome of these nationalist struggles, particularly now at the end of the twentieth century when transnational organizations like the European Union and the United Nations are playing a more active role in world affairs.

The collapse of the Soviet Union and the breakup of Yugoslavia notwithstanding, because of the tremendous power of the state and the reluctance of the international community to interfere in the internal affairs of any one state, outright secession has not been a common result of nationalist movements (Brass 1976:240). Most often states are able to accommodate the more moderate demands such groups make for cultural and political autonomy, while at the same time resisting their more extreme demands for complete independence. As Milton Esman (1977:389) points out, however, the price states must pay to avoid disintegration is to abandon their assimilationist policies and renounce the ultimate goal of an ethnically homogeneous nation-state. In order to save the state, in other words, it is often necessary to sacrifice the nation.[10]

[10] On the threat posed by ethnic conflict to the security and stability of contemporary states, see Brass (1985), Horowitz (1985), and Tambiah (1989).



## THE CONCEPT OF CULTURE IN NATIONALIST AND ANTHROPOLOGICAL DISCOURSE

The concept of culture occupies a position of central importance in both the discourse of nationalism and the discourse of anthropology, as do other concepts such as race, ethnicity, tradition, continuity, and identity. Furthermore, the rise of anthropology as an academic discipline and the rise of nationalism as a political ideology have common historical origins in Europe of the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, a period often referred to as "the age of nationalism." A consequence of this shared genealogy is that anthropological studies of nationalism run the risk of being reduced to tautologies (Spencer 1990:288).

To avoid this risk, anthropologists must strive to maintain sufficient analytic distance between the nationalist discourse they study and the anthropological discourse in which they write. This task is further complicated by the existence of still other discourses dealing with the very same issues of culture and identity. These include the political discourse on ethnicity in multicultural societies like Canada and Australia, as well as that of international organizations such as the United Nations and the Conference on Security and Cooperation in Europe. This discourse occupies in a sense an intermediate position between the essentialism of nationalist ideologies and the ascriptivitism of contemporary anthropology. All of these discourses are closely interelated; they draw on one another and shape one another in a variety of complex ways.

The most effective way for anthropologists to maintain the necessary analytic distance between their own anthropological discourse, on the one hand, and nationalist discourse, on the other, is to define the anthropological task as the deconstruction or dereification of the essentializing tendencies of nationalist conceptions of culture and identity. By demonstrating that culture and identity are socially and historically constructed, anthropologists can avoid unintentionally ratifying nationalist claims for the naturalness of national cultures and the innateness of national identities. Richard Handler (1985:174) suggests that anthropologists can accomplish this task by conducting what he describes as "destructive analysis" of national movements designed to challenge the commonsense notion of bounded, homogeneous cultures on which they are based. More specifically he suggests that anthropologists can avoid "buying into" nationalist ideologies by refraining from using terms such as "the Greek nation" or "the Macedonian nation," by not describing nations with metaphors of evolution, survival,

and collective individuality, and by not presenting people as members of unified cultural entities.

Although I agree with Handler up to this point, I feel that in his admirable desire to establish the requisite analytic distance between anthropological and nationalist discourse he has failed to distinguish between the processes of reification and objectivation. According to Berger and Luckmann (1967:82–83), reification involves the apprehension of the products of human activity as if they were something other than human products, as if they were natural phenomena or the expression of divine will. Objectivation, on the other hand, implies simply that reality, which is in fact socially constructed, is nevertheless experienced as an external and objective fact. While nations are reified in nationalist discourse, they must be dereified in anthropological analysis. Nations, however, do exist both as human products and as objective social facts, and anthropological analysis must acknowledge this.

I disagree with Handler, therefore, when he encourages anthropologists to avoid using terms of self-designation or introducing studies of nationalism with historical narratives (1985:178). It is both possible and appropriate for anthropologists to use terms like "Greek" or "Macedonian," not to refer to people who share a common essence, but to refer to a demonstrably diverse group of people who nevertheless choose to adopt a common national identity. Similarly it is possible to write a historical narrative, not of the Greek or the Macedonian nation, but of Greek or Macedonian nationalism. It is possible, in other words, to write an account of the process by which the Greek or the Macedonian nation was socially constructed.

Anthropologists analyzing the process by which national cultures and identities are created must also be careful to avoid simply presenting an exposé in which the premises on which nationalist ideologies are based are undermined or dismissed as inaccurate, mistaken, or simply wrong (Badone 1992:809). In addition, anthropologists must not allow their analyses to be used by hostile governments or an unsympathetic public to undercut the cultural authority of minority groups or indigenous peoples by calling into question the authenticity of their cultures (Linnekin 1991:446). It is in this context that phrases like "the invention of tradition" (Hobsbawm and Ranger 1983) and "imagined communities" (Anderson 1983) must be used with care. Anthropologists need to stress that "invented" and "imagined" are to be understood in the sense of "constructed," "fashioned," or "created," not in the sense of "imaginary," "false," or "unreal."

Anthropologists, therefore, have two often conflicting responsibilities. On the one hand, they have an intellectual obligation to deconstruct the reifying tendencies of the nationalist ideologies they study.



On the other, they have an ethical responsibility to ensure that their "destructive" analyses are not used against groups of people whose cultural authenticity is legitimated by such ideologies. Anthropologists can meet these conflicting responsibilities by avoiding both the reifying language of nationalism and the rhetorical excesses inherent in the use of terms like "imagined" or "invented." They can also explicitly reject any interpretation of their work that reduces it to a simple ratification of some nationalist ideology, as well as any interpretation that implies that because cultural traditions are constructed they are therefore unauthentic or unreal.[11] In this way, anthropologists can affirm the right of minority groups and indigenous people living in states with assimilationist policies to construct and preserve their own distinct cultures and identities, but at the same time point out the tendency of many minority rights movements to assert the authenticity of their own cultures while denying the authenticity of others. After all, from an anthropological perspective all identities and cultures are both equally constructed and equally real.[12]

As Richard Handler (1988:8) points out, among the dominant metaphors used in nationalist discourse to describe national cultures are those of naturalness, homogeneity, boundedness, and continuity. National cultures are considered to be territorially based and mutually exclusive. Since a nation is portrayed metaphorically as a collective individual or a natural species, a national culture is something a nation possesses; it is a nation's property, and its existence "proves the existence of the nation itself" (Handler 1988:51). Just as nationalists lay claim to a clearly bounded national territory, they "construct an account of the unique culture and history that attaches to and emanates from the people who occupy it. It is at this point that disputes about the ownership of cultural property come into play" (154).

In their extreme form these disputes involve metaphorical or even literal attempts to treat some aspect of a nation's history or culture as a trademark, as something on which a copyright has been placed, marking it as "belonging" to one and only one nation. Attempts by one nation to appropriate some aspect of the history or culture of another may therefore be treated as seriously as threats to a nation's territorial integrity. For history and culture, like territory, are the objective manifestations of a nation's existence.[13]

[11] For a thoughtful discussion of these issues see Linnekin (1991) and Hanson (1991).

[12] This does not imply, however, that all nationalist histories are equally accurate. The fact that one nationalist history corresponds less closely to some "objective" or "impartial" historical record than another, does not mean that the culture or the identity legitimated by that history is any less "real."

[13] See Herzfeld (1991) for an excellent study dealing with the politics of culture and the disputed ownership of history.

Anthropologists have traditionally regarded cultures as discrete, bounded, and homogeneous units, just as nationalists have. More recently, however, anthropologists have begun to stress the unbounded, continuously changing, fluid, and permeable aspects of cultural reality. Eric Wolf, for example, rejects the notion of bounded and self-contained cultures, an idea he associates with the political project of nationalism. Instead, he suggests that a culture can be better seen as "a series of processes that construct, reconstruct, and dismantle cultural materials, in response to definite determinants" (1982:387). Wolf elaborates as follows:

> We can no longer think of societies as isolated and self-maintaining systems. Nor can we imagine cultures as integrated totalitites in which each part contributes to the maintenance of an organized, autonomous, and enduring whole. There are only cultural sets of practices and ideas, put into play by determinate human actors under determinate circumstances. In the course of action these cultural sets are forever assembled, dismantled, and reassembled. (390–91)

Similarly Drummond (1980) develops the concept of a "cultural continuum" in order to emphasize the importance of internal variation and difference in understanding cultural reality, particularly in the case of multiethnic societies. For Drummond culture is not an isolated, homogeneous, integrated system, but an "intersystem," a continuum of overlapping differences, characterized by heterogeneity and change. It is out of just such complex cultural reality that nationalist movements attempt to create territorially bounded culturally homogeneous nations.[14]

According to the logic of nationalism, because nations are equated with states and because states have unambiguous, clearly defined territorial borders, nations must have such borders as well. Complex cultural realities, however, know no such borders. While a particular village must be located on one side or the other of the border separating two sovereign states, the people who live in this village are likely to speak more than one language and participate in more than one culture. It would be a mistake, however, to assume that the inhabitants of this village speak the two national languages and participate in the two national cultures of the nation-states whose border the village lies near. The people of this village do not inhabit two homogeneous, bounded national cultures; they inhabit a cultural continuum, a cultural intersystem, in which cultural differences and similarities coexist in complex and constantly changing ways.

[14] For a more recent formulation of this critique of anthropological approaches to culture, see Clifford (1988).



This discussion of ethnic nationalism and the construction of national identities and cultures provides a theoretical framework for the following analysis of the conflict between Greeks and Macedonians over which group has the right to identify itself as Macedonian. This dispute involves a variety of complex issues: competing claims to the same identity, history, and territory; transnational disputes over the human rights of the Macedonian minority in northern Greece and the recognition of the Republic of Macedonia as a sovereign and independent state; as well as the construction and negotiation of national identities at the individual level by immigrants from northern Greece to diaspora communities in multicultural societies like Canada and Australia.

I hope that this analysis will contribute not only to an understanding of the Macedonian conflict in particular, but also to an understanding of ethnic nationalism more generally. In this way it may offer some insight into how ethnic nationalism can be prevented from destroying the very societies and cultures it creates.